



In the late 5th century, the Mexican city of Monte Albán began to build its public buildings—the ancestors of its later magnificent pyramids, shown here.

IN THE ROMAN REPUBLIC, the two social classes—the patricians and the plebeians (see 500–491 BCE)—were still divided. The two sides came to an agreement in 451 BCE, appointing a group of ten men (**the decemviri**) to govern Rome outside the normal constitution. In 449 BCE, the decemviri produced the **Laws of the Twelve Tables**, which formed the basis for all Roman law codes.

Around 450 BCE in Central Europe, a **new Celtic culture emerged**, called **La Tène**, which supplanted the earlier dominant

villages. Monte Albán's center housed **large-scale public buildings**—including truncated pyramids, great plazas, and ballgame courts—as well as elaborate burial tombs. Within 150 years, the population of Monte Albán would swell to around 17,000, making it the **largest city in Mesoamerica**.

Zapotec figure from Monte Albán
This elaborate ceramic deity is typical of the production of Monte Albán, which became Mexico's premier site in the 5th century BCE.



ATHENS AND SPARTA HAD FOUGHT EACH OTHER BEFORE (see 451 BCE).

The Athenian Empire had the **naval advantage** as it included most of the island and coastal states around the northern and eastern shores of the Aegean Sea. Meanwhile, the city-state of Sparta led an alliance of independent states from the Peloponnese and central Greece, as well as Corinth, and had the **strongest army**. Despite the Thirty Years' Peace of 446 BCE, tensions remained high between Athens and Sparta. The events that led to **renewed**

“**THE EMPIRE YOU POSSESS IS BY NOW LIKE A TYRANNY—PERHAPS WRONG TO ACQUIRE IT, BUT CERTAINLY DANGEROUS TO LET IT GO.**”

Thucydides, ancient Greek historian, relating a speech by Pericles to the Athenians; from *History of the Peloponnesian War*, II.63

hostilities in 430 BCE began three years earlier, when Athens had intervened on behalf of Corcyra in a dispute with Corinth; the Spartans took it as a sign that Athens had breached the peace. An attack by Thebes, a Spartan ally, on Plataea, which supported Athens, was similarly taken by the Athenians to indicate Sparta was fixed on war. Athens, led by Pericles, achieved early success in the **Peloponnesian War** (431–404 BCE). In 426 BCE, **the Athenians invaded the Peloponnese**, and the following year landed a large

force at Pylos southwest of Sparta. Yet neither side could land a fatal blow and in 421 BCE they agreed the **Peace of Nicias**, which was supposed to last for 50 years.

The truce soon began to unravel. Corinth refused to recognize its authority, a pro-war leadership emerged in Sparta, and a complex set of political maneuvers by **Alcibiades** (450–404 BCE), the newly dominant politician in Athens, led to the **renewal of the war** in 419 BCE. The following year, Sparta's allies won a **key victory at Mantinea**. Athens struck back

SOCRATES (469–399 BCE)

One of the greatest Greek philosophers, Socrates served on the Athenian Council in 406 BCE, but his challenges to conventional morality at a time of political uncertainty gained him powerful enemies. He refused to mount a conventional defense against charges of corrupting the Athenian youth and was sentenced to die by drinking the poison hemlock.



12 THE NUMBER OF TABLES OF ROMAN LAW

Halstatt culture. Ruled over by a warrior aristocracy that buried its dead with swords, spears, and funerary chariots, **La Tène** had important centers in Bohemia (in what is now the Czech Republic) and around the Marne and Moselle rivers (in modern France).

In Oaxaca on Mexico's Pacific Coast, a new center arose shortly before 450 BCE at **Monte Albán**. This proto-city, on a hilltop above the Oaxaca Valley, drew people from the surrounding agricultural

